

NEVER AN ADEYEMI

EPISODE 4: FILE SEVENTEEN-B

PALMFIRE SEASON 1

Screenplay draft

Based on Mario's final story brief and story bible

Contemporary Lagos romance with stakes

FADE IN:

INT. TOBI'S APARTMENT - DAWN

Tobi pins three names to a wall: EMMANUEL AFOLABI, FILE 17-B, OLD ADEYEMI TRADING.

He calls Ify. She answers after the third ring.

IFY (V.O.)

You found the empty cabinet.

TOBI

I found the direction.

IFY (V.O.)

That is not the same thing.

TOBI

It is the only thing we have.

IFY (V.O.)

Then do not lose it.

Tobi writes LAGOS LAND REGISTRY beneath AFO LABI.

CUT TO:

INT. ADEYEMI OPERATING BUSINESS - ARCHIVE CORRIDOR - MORNING

Tobi tries the archive door. A SECURITY OFFICER blocks him.

SECURITY OFFICER

Mr. Kunle said no one enters.

TOBI

I am one of the owners.

SECURITY OFFICER

The estate is frozen.

TOBI

Then the door should be frozen too.

Through the glass, the old cabinet stands empty.

TOBI

Who removed the boxes?

SECURITY OFFICER

I do not know.

TOBI

That is becoming a careful answer.

The records clerk avoids his eyes. Tobi sees a delivery label with an old company address.

CUT TO:

EXT. LAGOS STATE LAND REGISTRY - DAY

The building is hot, crowded and full of people waiting for files that have outlived their labels. Tobi places a copy of the deed before a RECORDS OFFICER.

RECORDS OFFICER

This reference is too old.

TOBI

The current title tells you the property changed hands.

RECORDS OFFICER

Everything changes hands.

TOBI

Who filed the change?

RECORDS OFFICER

Adeyemi Holdings.

TOBI

And before that?

RECORDS OFFICER

A room that no longer exists.

An ELDERLY WOMAN at the next counter studies Tobi's face.

ELDERLY WOMAN

You are looking for the old company.

TOBI

I am looking for Emmanuel Afolabi.

ELDERLY WOMAN

Ask Mrs. Bisola Aina. She typed his letters.

TOBI

Where does she live?

ELDERLY WOMAN

Go before she decides you are another Adeyemi asking for the past.

CUT TO:

INT. MRS. AINA'S HOUSE - AFTERNOON

MRS. BISOLA AINA, seventies, opens her door halfway. Boxes of labelled papers fill the sitting room.

MRS. AINA

You are late.

TOBI

I did not know I was invited.

MRS. AINA

You are not. That is why you are late.

Tobi shows the photograph of the two boys.

TOBI

I am looking for Afolabi.

MRS. AINA

Everyone looking for him has a family story.

TOBI

I have one. My father was Obinna Obi.

Her expression changes.

MRS. AINA

You are his boy.

TOBI

Yes.

MRS. AINA

Afolabi left after the old deed was registered.

TOBI

Did he know it was forged?

MRS. AINA

He knew the signature did not belong to the man whose name it carried.

CUT TO:

INT. OLD LEGAL QUARTER - RECEPTION - LATE AFTERNOON

A tarnished sign reads AFOLABI & PARTNERS. The office behind it is empty. A LANDLORD opens an old rent book.

LANDLORD

Afolabi paid on time.

TOBI

Where did he go?

LANDLORD

He received a letter from your family.

TOBI

What kind of letter?

LANDLORD

The kind that makes a man move before he has packed.

The landlord shows him an Ibadan post-office stamp.

TOBI

Did he leave a forwarding address?

LANDLORD

He left one and took it back.

TOBI

Why?

LANDLORD

He was tired of the name above the door.

CUT TO:

INT. MRS. AINA'S HOUSE - EVENING

Mrs. Aina places a carbon copy on the table. The top line reads:
CLOSE FILE 17-B.

TOBI

This came from my family.

MRS. AINA

Your grandfather dictated it.

TOBI

To stop Afolabi speaking about the partnership?

MRS. AINA

To stop him calling the replacement deed what it was.

TOBI

Did he obey?

MRS. AINA

He stopped speaking to the family. He kept writing.

She takes out a second card.

MRS. AINA

He moved to a church guesthouse in Ibadan.
Do not take the first answer he gives you.

TOBI

Why not?

MRS. AINA

Because the first answer is usually the one
that kept him alive.

Tobi reads the Ibadan address. The family letter sits between them
like a threat that has not finished travelling.

FADE OUT.